DIOCLETIAN'S PALACE

The Succession - rules for four players

Read pages 1 and 2 aloud to start playing. The rest can wait until the succession phase begins.

The goal

What you are trying to do

Diocletian has retired. Four rivals prepare a claim to the throne. Collect equipment to become strong, earn Prestige to pay for help, and win the support of two of the three factions in the city. Then stand at the Peristyle, the great crossing of the palace, and proclaim your claim. If none of your three rivals can stop it, the throne is yours.

What you need

- This printed kit: the board (four taped pages), six treasure cards, the tokens, and one player sheet per person.
- Two ordinary six-sided dice for movement, and one six-sided die for fights (any die works for both - you just need three dice in total).
- A small pawn per player. Coins or buttons work. The paper pawns in this kit also work.
- About 45 to 75 minutes for four players learning the game.

How to set up

o Assemble the board (see the assembly sheet). Each player picks a pawn and a player sheet, and writes their name on it.

o Shuffle the six treasure cards face down. Place one on each treasure entry, the double circles marked A to F. Nobody may look yet.

o Give each player a random gate: Golden (north), Silver (east), Bronze (south), or Iron (west). Put your pawn on your gate.

o Choose a starting player at random. The start moves one seat clockwise at the beginning of every round.

DIOCLETIAN'S PALACE - RULES

The Succession

Your turn

One turn, three steps

- Roll two dice. The total is the maximum number of steps you may take.
- Move your pawn along the street circles, one circle per step, north, south, east or west. You may stop before using the whole roll and you may pass through circles occupied by other pawns.
- Do one action where you stand - or do nothing. Taking treasure, standing guard, duelling, gaining support and proclaiming are all actions. You never do two of these on the same turn.

What counts as movement

The white circles are streets. The hatched blocks are buildings: nobody walks through them. All movement and all distances are counted along street circles, not across buildings.

Guard duty and duels are actions of a moving turn: you must move at least one circle first. Taking treasure, gaining support, claiming the checkpoint and proclaiming may be done without moving.

Rounds and turns

A round is one turn for every player, in clockwise order from the starting player. After the last player, a new round begins and the start moves one seat clockwise, so nobody always plays first.

Treasure and equipment

The six treasures

Each treasure entry (double circle, A to F) holds one face-down card: pugio, pilum, galea, scutum, gladius, or lorica segmentata.

End your move on the entry to take that card's action: reveal the card to everyone and mark the item on your player sheet.

Every player can collect every item once. The cards stay on the board face up once revealed; they are never taken away, stolen, or lost. If you are the first to stop at an entry, you learn for everyone what waits there.

Why equipment matters

Equipment makes you stronger in every duel for the rest of the game:

Items collected	Bonus on your duel roll
0 to 2	+0
3 to 5	+1
all 6	+2

You can keep collecting missing items during the succession phase. Nothing is ever granted for free - if you want it, walk and get it.

Prestige

Earning Prestige

- Guard post (star): end a move there and roll one die. A 4, 5 or 6 earns 1 Prestige.
- Win a duel: the winner of any duel earns 1 Prestige.
- Open the checkpoint: the first player to complete the set of six and claim at the Peristyle earns 1 Prestige.

You can hold at most 3 Prestige. Any reward above three is lost - spend it or waste it.

Duels

End your move within two street circles of a rival and you may duel them as your action. The attacker and the defender each roll one die and add their equipment bonus. The higher total wins; on a tie the attacker wins. The winner earns 1 Prestige.

Nobody loses equipment, support or Prestige (beyond what was declared below).

Before rolling, the attacker may declare a boosted duel: pay 1 Prestige to add +2 to your roll. You pay even if you lose. The defender cannot pay for a bonus.

Spending Prestige

- 1 Prestige: one faction's support (next page).
- 1 Prestige: the +2 boost on a duel you attack in.
- 1 Prestige: the mandatory fee to contest a proclaimed claim (next page).

Factions and the claim

The three factions

Three groups in the city can back your claim. Their meeting places are marked on the board with badges:

Faction	Badge	Meeting place
Army	shield	Treasure entry F
Imperial officials	column	the Peristyle crossing
City elites	laurel	Treasure entry A

Visit a meeting place and spend 1 Prestige to gain that faction's support. There is no roll. Every faction can support every player, but each faction supports each player only once. Support lasts the whole game. You may gain support in either phase of the game.

From the city to the succession

The game has two phases. In the city phase everyone collects equipment and Prestige. The first player who owns all six items may stand at the Peristyle and claim the checkpoint as their action: they earn 1 Prestige. Finish that round, then one more full round, and the succession phase begins. If nobody claims by the end of round 24, the succession begins anyway.

At the change, every pawn stays where it stands and keeps everything it owns. Missing equipment is not granted - you can still walk and collect it.

Proclaiming a claim

- During the succession phase, stand at the Peristyle with support from two different factions.
- Use your action to proclaim your claim. Place the CLAIM marker on the Peristyle. Only one claim can stand at a time.
- Every rival now gets one response turn, in normal turn order. On a response turn a rival may contest you (below), or do anything else they could normally do - move, collect, earn Prestige - which counts as letting your claim stand for that turn.
- If your turn comes while your claim stands and you are still at the Peristyle, you may maintain the claim as your action and stay put. Leaving the Peristyle by your own move cancels your claim.
- If all three rivals finish their response with your claim intact, you are acclaimed emperor and the game ends.

Contesting a claim

How to contest

A rival can stop a claim by winning a challenge duel against the claimant. To do it, end your response turn's move within two street circles of the claimant and duel them. Challenging a standing claim costs a mandatory fee of 1 Prestige, paid before you roll - even if you lose. Without at least 1 Prestige you cannot contest at all.

The challenge itself is a normal duel: one die each, add equipment bonuses, attacker wins ties. On top of the fee you may also declare the boost: 1 further Prestige for +2 on your roll. With the fee and the boost together, a full challenge costs 2 Prestige.

What happens on each result

- You win: the claim is canceled. The claimant's pawn returns to their gate. They keep all equipment, Prestige and support - only the claim is lost. The next claim may be proclaimed at any time.
- You lose: the claim stands. Your Prestige is spent either way.

An example challenge

Livia has proclaimed at the Peristyle with the Army and the elites behind her. Marcus, holding 3 Prestige and four items, moves next to the crossing. His response turn: he pays the 1 Prestige fee, declares the boost for 1 more, and rolls 5 + 1 (equipment) + 2 (boost) = 8. Livia rolls 4 + 2 (all six items) = 6. Marcus wins; the claim is canceled and Livia's pawn goes back to her gate with everything she owns. Had Livia rolled 6 or more, the challenge would have failed and Marcus's 2 Prestige would still be gone.

If nobody wins

If no claim survives by the end of round 24 of the succession phase, the game ends in a draw - the throne stays empty. This is rare.

Remember

- An ordinary duel is free. Challenging a claim always costs the 1 Prestige fee. The +2 boost is optional and costs 1 more.
- Everything is public: positions, items, Prestige, support, and who has responded to a claim. Only the face-down cards and the next dice roll are hidden.

Common questions

Can I pass through another pawn?

Yes. Pawns never block a street.

Can two pawns share a circle?

Yes, any number may stand on one circle.

Do I have to use my whole roll?

No. Stop anywhere up to the total.

Can I duel the claimant for free while no claim stands?

Yes. Between claims the claimant is an ordinary rival and duels are free.

Can the claimant boost their defense?

No. Only the attacker may pay for the +2 boost.

I have 3 Prestige and win a guard roll. Nothing happens - the cap is 3. Spend some first.?

Can a faction support two different players?

Yes - every faction can back every player once.

Can I proclaim twice?

Yes, if your first claim is canceled, walk back and proclaim again. Support is never lost.

Do treasures run out?

No. Every player can mark each of the six items.

What if two players reach six items on the same round?

The first to claim at the Peristyle in turn order is the first challenger.